the BJP and "instead question its MLAs about the seized money". Though the ruling alliance leaders believe the "attempt to bring down the Soren government has failed", the incident has created a trust deficit among the alliance partners.

The JMM-Congress-RJD coalition had won a reasonable majority of 49 seats in the 81-member house (JMM 30, Congress 18 and RJD 1) in the 2019 assembly election, but the suspension of three Congress MLAs and the shadow of disqualification over CM Soren may force the coalition to unravel.

The biggest worry now is the Election Commission, which is looking into a BJP plaint seeking Soren's disqualification for owning a mining lease. Soren's younger brother and MLA, Basant Soren, is also on EC notice over a similar complaint. The JMM chief also faces corruption allegations and his political aide Pankaj Mishra was recently arrested by the Enforcement Directorate.

Before the cash-in-car incident, a section of Congress MLAs had come under the radar during the presidential election. The party-backed opposition candidate, Yashwant Sinha, got just nine votes, though the two alliance partners, Congress and RJD, together had 19 MLAs in the state. While one vote was rejected, the news is that at least nine MLAs had cross-voted. The message was loud and clear—a section of the ruling alliance MLAs was willing prey, awaiting the poacher's viewfinder.

If that's true and the seizure in Howrah was part of a 'toppling' operation, then it would be the second alleged attempt on the Hemant Soren government, which has little over two years left in its tenure. In July 2021, the state police had arrested three 'political workers', including a liquor contractor, for allegedly hatching a conspiracy to topple the government. Then too, Jaimangal Singh had lodged an FIR alleging some financiers were camping in Ranchi with the intention of destabilising the alliance government. ■

JET LAGGED

On July 28, two pilots of the Indian Air Force (IAF)—Wing Commander Mohit Rana and Flight Lieutenant Advitiya Bal—lost their lives after their **MiG-21** jet crashed in the Barmer district of Rajasthan. The peacetime deaths have reignited the debate around how safe it is to fly MiG-21s—considered the IAF's workhorse—beyond their life. The IAF says it has no choice, because the world's fourth-ranked air force (in terms of number of military aircraft) simply doesn't have enough fighter jets in its fleet.

IAF got its first single-engine MiG-21 in 1963, the longest in service for the force

Gradually IAF went on to induct 874 jets from different MiG variants

Considered a supersonic fighter, the MiG-21 is of a 1960s vintage design

The IAF has lost 400 MiGs in crashes since 1971, which have claimed the lives of over 200 pilots and nearly 50 civilians



The Soviet-era MiG-21 was designed to fly at a high altitude as a high-speed interceptor to shoot down US bombers, but the IAF has been using it for everything else too

By **PRADIP R. SAGAR**

ASSAM

LANGUAGE OF CONTENTION

By Kaushik Deka

A day before Union home minister Amit Shah publicly advocated the teaching of even engineering, medicine and law in regional languages, the BJP-led Assam government had taken quite a contrary decision on July 28, making it compulsory for all government schools to teach mathematics and science in English instead of Assamese or other vernacular languages from class 3 to class 12. The government also announced that 5-10 schools in each district would have English as a medium of instruction in all subjects, parallel to Assamese, Bodo and Bengali, with students choosing the language they would be taught in from class 6 to class 12.

The decision has stirred a controversy as it goes against the essence of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, which lays much stress on regional language as the medium of instruction. A section titled 'Multilingualism and the power language' reads: "[...] young children learn and grasp nontrivial concepts more quickly in their home language/mother tongue... Wherever possible, the medium of instruction until at least Grade 5, but preferably till Grade 8 and beyond, will be the home language/mother tongue/local language/regional language." Senior officials in the Union ministry of education agree that the decision is not in sync with the NEP. "It makes sense to teach in